Guidelines to Evidence Based Practice

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Outlines:

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2. Definition of EB guidelines for nursing.
3. Benefits of guidelines.
4. Stages of guidelines development.
5. Characteristics of effective guidelines.
6. EBP guidelines dissemination and implementation.

Introduction:

- Guidelines are developed by panels or groups of experienced individuals who carefully weigh syntheses of evidence and the strength of the evidence before developing recommendations for interventions.

- Nurses need to have an active role in guideline development or the adaptation of existing guidelines to local circumstances. This approach will encourage a sense of ownership of the guideline and is more likely to lead to more positive attitudes towards it.

Definition: Evidence-based guidelines, also called clinical practice guidelines, "are systematically developed statements to assist practitioner and patient decisions about appropriate health care for specific clinical circumstances."

☒ **Benefits of EB guidelines:**

1. Guidelines can be used to reduce inappropriate variations in practice.
2. Promote the delivery of high quality, evidence-based health care.
3. They may also provide a mechanism by which healthcare professionals can be made accountable for clinical activities.
4. Nurses are becoming more interested in the use of guidelines as one means of facilitating evidence-based practice.
5. Improve patient experience.
6. Decrease costs.

- **Guideline development:**
- **Guideline development has 4 stages:**
- **I. Literature search:** detailed literature search is done to identify evidence from research studies about the appropriateness and effectiveness of different clinical strategies.
- **II. Guideline construction:** Next, using the research evidence, guideline construction takes place, usually through some form of small group work, with representation from as many interested parties as possible.
- **III. Guideline testing:** Then, the guideline is tested by asking professionals not involved in the guideline development to review it for clarity, internal consistency, and acceptability. The guideline can then be tested in selected healthcare settings to see whether it is feasible for use in routine practice.
- **IV. Guideline reviews:** Finally, the guideline should be reviewed after a specified period and modified to take into account new knowledge.

❖ **Characteristics of EBP Effective Guidelines:**

If guidelines are to be effective, they need to have most, if not all, of the following 6 characteristics:

1. **Validity:** Validity means that if a guideline is followed, it should lead to the health gains and costs predicted.
2. **Reliability:** Reliability means that given the same clinical circumstances, another health professional would apply the recommendations similarly; both are more likely to occur if the guideline is developed systematically and rigorously.
3. **Clinically applicable:** For a guideline to be clinically applicable the target population should be defined in line with scientific evidence.

4. Flexibility: Guidelines should also be flexible by identifying exceptions and how patient preferences are to be taken into account in the decision-making process.

5. Clear: Guidelines should be clear using precise definitions and user-friendly formats.

6. Systemic review: Guidelines should also, be reviewed periodically and modified to incorporate new knowledge.

Guidelines dissemination and implementation:

Once a clinical guideline is ready for use, 2 stages facilitate its introduction into practice: dissemination and implementation.

- **1- Dissemination:** Refers to the method by which guidelines are made available to potential users.

➢**Dissemination strategies include:**

1. Publication in professional journals.

2.Sending guidelines to targeted individuals, as well as strategies involving an educational intervention**.**

☒ **Benefits of dissemination:**

1. Supporting research.
2. Enhancing the credibility of official statistics.
3. Improving the reliability and relevance of data.
4. Reducing duplication in data collection.
5. Promoting development of new tools for using data.

- **2- Implementation:**
  - Means ensuring that users subsequently act upon the recommendations.
  - Implementation is a more active process, involving tailoring the message to the needs of the target audience and actively working to overcome barriers to behavior change.

➢ **Implementation strategies include:**

1. Try to ensure that users adopt and apply guidelines to which they have access.
2. Barriers to behavior change such as structural (e.g., staff workload and financial resources) and attitudinal factors (e.g., acceptance of guidelines and willingness to change) should be considered.
3. Appropriate interventions might be targeted at both the structure and process of care.